

1853-54

APRIL 1854

The Emigrant Aid Society is formed in Massachusetts to help antislavery settlers move to Kansas to ensure it remains a free territory under the doctrine of "popular sovereignty."

MAY 1854

The Kansas-Nebraska Act divides the former Kansas territory into two. The slave or free status of Kansas is uncertain, though it lies north of the line established by the 1820 Missouri Compromise.

JULY 1854

The new Republican Party holds its first convention in Michigan. It opposes the Kansas-Nebraska Act and supports slavery in the territories.